



Crossing a line: All-rounder Ben Stokes and pace bowler Gus Atkinson will not play in the second Test against New Zealand after being involved in an incident in a London nightclub in the early hours. AFP

also takes away the need to write about the substandard pitch at Lord's and ignore the demerit point and the unsatisfactory rating given by ICC, and focus on something more spicy.

Stokes and Atkinson have both lost out financially by not being picked for the second Test match and perhaps the third Test too, pending the investigation into the incident. They could be fined too, just like Brook was fined by the England & Wales Cricket Board for the incident in New Zealand.

Speaking of fines, it would be interesting to know where the fines go. Into which account and what is done with it. Does it reflect in the balance sheet, and if it does, under which category does it appear? In the IPL, too, there are fines imposed on players, but where do the fines go? To the captains and players, it makes no difference as the fines are taken care of by the franchise, so it's neither a penalty nor a deterrence. Even if the accumulation of demerit points leads to a one-match ban, it

doesn't make much of a difference.

For any penalty to be effective, it has to have an impact on the match. Like the penalty of one less fielder outside the 30-metre circle in case the team has not bowled its next over within 60 seconds thrice. That can have an impact on the game, especially in the final overs of the innings.

The BCCI's ban for two years on those who enter the auction and, after being picked, then withdraw at the last moment, not for injury but brownie points with their local media, is another good move. They should also ban those who come to the IPL and, when they find they aren't being picked regularly, feign an injury and return home and then play in their domestic cricket even while the IPL is still going on.

Plenty of overseas players take the IPL for granted and sometimes, in connivance with their Boards, make some excuse and not play in the full tournament as they agreed before they entered the auction.

The franchise cannot go running

around for a replacement at this late hour, and so has no option but to wait for the Board to release the player. Remember, the Boards get 10% of the player fee, not from the player. This is an additional cost to the franchise, and that is why it is important for BCCI to be firm and ensure this does not happen. Cutting the player's fee according to the number of matches he is missing should also apply to the percentage that the overseas Boards get for their player.

The cricketing world has been ruled by the old powers without giving anything to the other Boards. Here, BCCI is giving to the Boards too, and so should be telling them not to take the helplessness of the franchise as a weakness and to cancel the contracts of those who don't want to play the full tournament. No compromises. This is the IPL, not just the best T20 tournament in the world, but also the making of millionaires out of some really ordinary overseas players.